



The external SSD market has moved from niche backup gadget to essentials for laptops, consoles and phones. Since early 2025, faster USB standards and higher capacities have gone mainstream, with NVMe based drives pushing sequential speeds far beyond what portable hard drives ever delivered. Creators and gamers now expect portable storage that can cut 4K timelines straight from the drive, move project folders in minutes and keep up with ever-growing game sizes without feeling like a bottleneck.

Alongside sheer speed, brands focus on tougher designs, better thermals and more predictable sustained performance. IP rated shells, rubber exteriors and smarter controllers work together to keep transfers steady once caches fill, while the rise of Type C iPhones and high bitrate video recording has pushed vendors to think seriously about phone first workflows.

Zero1 Winner and Best Buy: **Crucial X10 Portable SSD**

The Crucial X10 walks away with both the Zero1 Award and the Best Buy title, a rare double that speaks to its blend of raw

speed and accessible pricing. Leveraging a USB 3.2 Gen 2x2 interface and a fast NVMe drive inside, the X10 Pro pushed past the 2 GB/s mark in our sequential transfer tests and held impressively high numbers once we moved to large mixed file copies. More importantly, it maintained those speeds for far longer than most rivals before thermals and cache behaviour dragged things down, which is exactly what serious editors and data heavy workflows tend to expose first.

In real projects, that translated into snappier scrubbing on heavy 4K timelines and very quick ingest of high resolution stills into editing suites. Even when used as a scratch drive for large Photoshop composites and batch exports, the X10 Pro stayed cool enough to avoid obvious throttling. Longer random access runs and mixed queue depth tests also showed very little stutter, making it feel closer to an internal SSD than an external add-on. Backup jobs over USB always remained pleasantly brisk and predictable. The compact, rounded shell fits easily into cramped laptop bags, and its IP55 rating adds some much-needed reassurance for people who travel with their entire project library. Considering its Indian street pricing, the number of workloads where this drive felt unapologetically “desktop class” was what clinched both awards.

Runner-up: **SanDisk Creator Phone SSD**

The SanDisk Creator Phone SSD takes a very different approach, focusing on mobile shooting first and general storage second. MagSafe compatibility lets the drive latch onto the back of iPhones, so creators can shoot ProRes or high bitrate clips straight to external storage without cables and clamps. Rated for up to 1000 MB/s reads and 950 MB/s writes, it kept up with our 4K 60 fps recording tests, and never felt like it would tap out mid take, even the camera rolled for extended sequences.

SanDisk’s silicone wrapped design, IP65 rating and three metre drop resistance also made the Creator Phone SSD feel properly field ready. The bundled cable and magnet ring keep setup simple, whether you are attaching it to a phone case, tablet or the back of a lightweight laptop screen. For laptop and desktop use it works like a normal SSD, and while it could not match the Crucial X10 Pro in sustained heavy copy jobs, its blend of flexibility, phone first ergonomics and solid real world speeds still put it ahead of a crowd of conventional portable drives. The fact that it extends the working life of a phone by offloading storage and write cycles is something that many creators will quietly appreciate.



External SSDs

Fast storage, flexible workflows



Crucial X10 Portable SSD
Price: ₹14,999

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